

How to write better instructions for Excel agents

I. The Core Shift

Copilot Prompt

- Get a good answer now
- You steer the interaction
- Structure lives in the prompt

Agent Instructions

- Define behavior over time
- Users ask loosely
- Structure lives in the background

The mistake:

Copying a good Copilot prompt and stretching it into “instructions.”

That creates an agent that sounds thoughtful... but behaves vaguely.

II. Prompts vs Instructions (Quick Comparison)

Dimension	Copilot Prompt	Agent Instructions
Purpose	Get a good answer now	Define consistent reasoning
Scope	One interaction	Many interactions
Failure Mode	Off answer → re-prompt	Plausible but unanchored output
What You’re Writing	A request	A role definition

Mental model shift:

Prompt = “How should this answer be framed?”

Agent = “What is this agent responsible for?”



III. The 6 Components of Strong Agent Instructions

Instead of improvising, follow a structure.

1. Purpose

Be specific and constrained.

Not “Analyze sales data.”

But:

Help users explain month-over-month revenue changes by separating price, volume, and mix effects, prioritizing transparency over certainty.

2. Guidelines

Write down the analytical discipline you normally carry in your head.

Examples:

- Avoid causal language.
- Tie claims to specific columns.
- Surface assumptions.
- Ask clarifying questions when underspecified.

This is what prevents confident nonsense.

3. Skills

Tell it what tools to use.

Examples:

- Validate aggregates with PivotTables.
- Recompute Revenue = Units × Price when needed.
- Use charts only if clarifying.
- Use Python only if decomposition becomes cumbersome.

Agents misbehave when capability exceeds discipline.



4. Workflow

Prevent “jumping to the answer.”

Example:

1. Confirm the period being compared
2. Validate totals
3. Decompose price / volume / mix
4. Summarize with assumptions visible

Defined sequence = reduced sloppiness.

5. Limitations

Give the agent permission to stop.

- If missing inputs → ask
- If asked for causality → explain limitation
- If history too short for forecast → state constraint

Careful agents are more trustworthy agents.

6. Examples

Show what “good” looks like.

One clean decomposition example.

One edge case where the agent pushes back.

You’re encoding judgment, not just formatting.



IV. The Real Difference

Bad instruction:

“Explain revenue changes clearly and concisely.”

Better instruction:

Validate totals → Decompose drivers → Reconcile → Communicate neutrally → Ask before assuming.

The second behaves reliably across users.

V. When Agent Mode Makes Sense

Use Copilot when:

- You’re exploring
- You’re steering each step

Use Agent Mode when:

- You want the same reasoning repeated consistently
- You want expectations embedded upfront
- You don’t want to restate your analytical standards every time

Agents work best when you capture the parts of your thinking that should not change.

